

CFO-RC FILE X:

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name) Barred Owl

(Scientific Name) *Strix varia*

Date(s) of occurrence: 20 January 2000

Number of birds seen: 2

Sex: pair ?

Plumage:

Exact location: Fence along Cimarron River at CO/KS border. The birds were first seen in KS and then flew into Colorado. Scott Seltman (KS) talked with survey crews and determined that the state line is only a few feet past the fence. When we last saw the bird it was 150 meters past the fence and well into Colorado.

County: Baca

Nearest town: Elkhart, KS

Elevation: less than 5000 ft?

Length of observation: 1 minute

Time(s) of observation: 9:30 PM (roughly)

Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Brandon Percival

Other Observers who independently saw the bird(s): None

Light Conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s); position: Bright full moon and spotlight. We saw the owl just before the eclipse started.

Optical equipment used: 10 x 42 B & L Elite binoculars

Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): 15 - 150 meters (when it was flying away into Colorado)

Was bird(s) photographed? No.

If so, have you submitted photos?

Describe the general and specific habitat in which the bird(s) occurred: The birds were seen in riparian woods along the Cimarron River. The trees were fairly well spaced. The bird landed in the densest clumps of trees around. Nevertheless, I was very surprised to have seen a Barred Owl in such sparse habitat.

Description: Brandon Percival and I were birding the Cimarron National Grasslands a few hours after dark, looking for Western Screech-Owls. The night was relatively warm and very calm. We were both surprised that we did not have any Western Screech-Owls respond given such perfect conditions. Knowing that Barred Owl had been collected in the area in 1992 (Cable et al), we decided to try to call one in. I whooped a few Barred Owl calls, which have elicited responses from Barred Owls in the Midwest and East. To our surprise, two owls flew in from the Kansas side and landed in a nearby grove of trees (still in Kansas). I rattled off a list of expletives and put the spotlight at one and looked at it with my binocular. When the light was on the owl, it bobbed its head up and down and looked around rapidly. This bird was perched midway up in the middle of a cottonwood. I, then, tried to find the other owl but had not see exactly where it landed. We moved closer to get a more direct look at the one owl we did see, when the two owls flew. Brandon and I were about 30 meters apart at the time and I think we ended up each watching a different one of the owls fly well into Colorado. We tried for another 2 hours to call the birds in, but without luck. A Great Horned Owl started calling about 20 minutes after we saw these owls, which certainly didn't help.

When the owls first flew in and when they flew away, I was struck by the thick-bodied appearance and very broad wings (compared to Great Horned Owl). They seemed to be slightly smaller than a Great Horned Owl, with a much chunkier and more rounded appearance. The head contrasted darker than the lighter colored flanks and body. The upper surface of the wings was the same color as the head and upperparts (in this light). When sitting, the bird's head was rounded, lacking ear tufts or any rectangular look. When the light was on the bird, the eyes appeared dark. The head and breast were dark (with a paler face) and contrasted with the birds paler belly and flanks. Branches prevented us from getting a good look at the underparts, but they were broadly streaked dark on a lighter background color. We did not see the birds well enough for a more detailed description.

Describe bird's call or song: None heard

Discuss similar species and how you eliminated them: Great Horned Owl has a completely different shape. The more rectangular shaped head and body are very different from this bird. When responding territorially, the ear tufts on that species are usually very obvious. The wings are not as broad. Great Horned Owls underparts are densely barred and do not contrast with a darker head. The whiter area on the throat is usually visible, as is the rusty face, which I would never describe as lighter than the rest of the head. Long-eared and Short-eared Owls are much longer winged. The former species ear tufts are usually prominent and the head is not as round. The darker underparts do not contrast darker than the head. I would be shocked if a Short-eared Owl flew into my imitation of a Barred Owl. Even more so, if two flew in and landed in the center of a tree! Male Short-eared Owls have paler bellies and flanks, but the streaking is much finer than on our bird. The flight style is more floating and erratic. All the previous species also have light eyes. The only similar shaped bird is Spotted Owl. I think I would have recognized a Spotted Owl on the basis of smaller size alone, given my familiarity with Barred Owl. Furthermore, Spotted Owl's underparts are much darker and more "spotted," though that doesn't really describe it well. In any event, they do not have blurry streaks on a paler surface of the belly and flanks and would be completely unexpected in this habitat, although some odd records exist.

This sighting, along with those detailed in Cable et al raise an interesting possibility that this species may be somewhat regular. All records in the area are from late fall and winter.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? I have seen 100+ Barred Owls under similar conditions. I have seen all other owls discussed above.

Lit cit: Cable, T., S. Seltman and K. J. Cook. 1996. Birds of Cimarron National Grasslands. USDA Forest Service: General Technical Report RM-GTR-281.

This report is from notes made during observation
Date of written report: 2 February 2001

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